

if your handycam has it, you can use its night lamp—basically an infrared lamp that illuminates its immediate surroundings enough for them to be visible to the camera. Unfortunately, this will cause your camera to record in greyscale, but you can get some really interesting effects. If you want a creepy shot of a black cat, for example, shine this light directly into its eyes (the cat won't suffer any harm). In fact, even human eyes get a very eerie look in this mode.

While inbuilt infrared LEDs are fine for shooting objects in the range of a few feet, for longer ranges you'll need a larger and more powerful infrared illuminator. Remember, though, that you won't see any light with your naked eye.

The Right White

The colour white looks different in different environments. For example, under fluorescent lights, it might have a bluish tinge, a yellowish one in the outdoors, and so on.

All handycams come with automatic white balance adjustments for different environments, but they may need tuning from time to time. The general procedure involves pointing your camera at a white surface and telling it that *this* is true white. You will need to consult your camera's manual for more details on how to calibrate its white balance.

5.5 From The TV To Your PC

With Media Center PCs available everywhere, and Windows Media Center being built by default into Windows Vista, your PC will soon become your primary source for TV programs, simply because of the convenience it offers. Pause shows while you go grab a bite, record your favourite programs, even skip through commercials—who wouldn't want that?